Game Jam Team Playbook

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Three people, 21 days, one finished game: aim for a playable build by day 7, feature freeze on day 16, and submit a day early.

Roles

Each person owns one area and has final say there; everyone still helps everywhere. Owning an area means you unblock it, not that you do all of it.

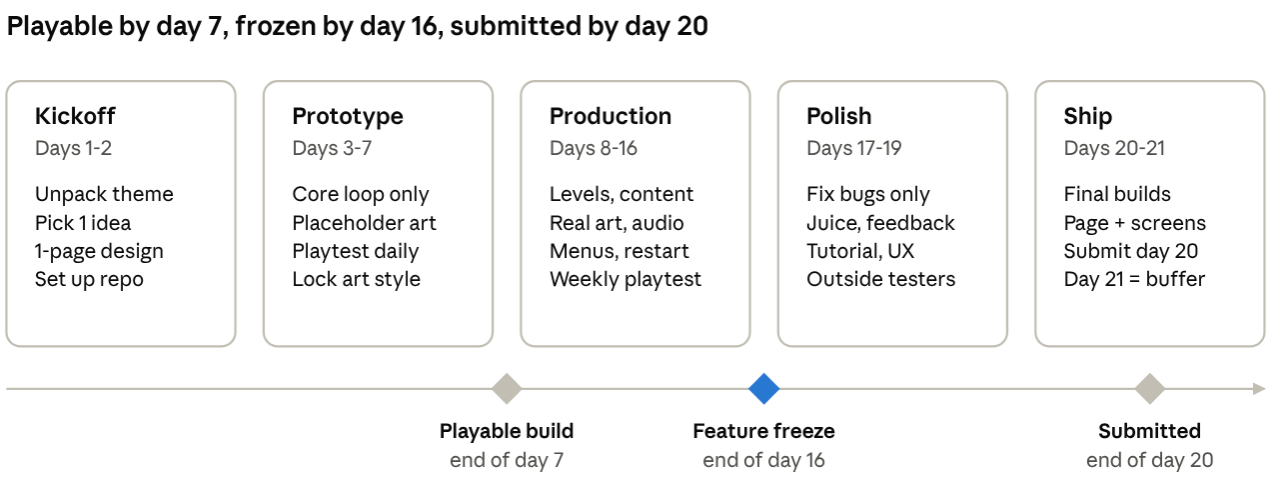
Role	Owns	Also covers
Lead / gameplay programmer	Core loop, player controls, build and repo health, final call on scope	Integrating everyone's work into the main branch
Systems / tools programmer	UI, menus, audio hookup, save/restart, level loading, bug triage	Level scripting, performance
Art / design / audio	Visual style guide, sprites or models, animation, sound and music, level layouts	Tuning numbers, writing, store page art

If you have two programmers and no artist, pick one strong, cheap art style on day 1 (flat colours, pixel art at low resolution, or free asset packs the jam allows) and let the third person own design, levels and audio instead.

One person is the **producer** for the whole jam: runs check-ins, keeps the task board honest and calls the cuts. Usually the lead; it can rotate weekly.

21-day plan

Three gates matter more than any feature: a playable build on day 7, feature freeze on day 16, and submission on day 20.



21-day plan · 5 phases, 3 gates

If a gate slips by more than a day, cut scope rather than move the next gate. Anything not in the build at freeze waits for a post-jam update.

Working rhythm

Online teams fail on silence, not on skill: post progress daily in writing and meet live only when it saves time.

When	What	Length
Every day, by a set hour	Written check-in in the team channel: done yesterday, doing today, blocked by	3 lines
Every 2–3 days	Short voice call: play the latest build together, re-sort the task board	20–30 min
Every Sunday	Weekly review: are we on track for the next gate? What do we cut?	45 min
Days 7, 12, 16, 19	Playtest by someone outside the team, watched on a screen share without helping	15 min each

- **Share your hours up front.** Each person posts their availability and time zone on day 1, including days they are away.
- **Overlap window.** Agree 1–2 hours a day when all three are usually online; save questions and calls for it.
- **Blocked for 30 minutes? Ask.** Post the question with a screenshot or clip rather than waiting for the next call.

- **Show, don't describe.** GIFs and short clips of new features in the channel keep morale up and catch misunderstandings early.
- **Disagreements.** The area owner decides within their area; the producer decides anything else. Decide in minutes, not days.
- **Protect sleep.** No all-nighters before day 19. A rested team fixes bugs faster than a tired one writes features.

Tools and setup

Use tools everyone already knows; day 1 is the wrong time to learn a new engine or version-control system.

Need	Suggested tool	Notes
Chat and calls	Discord server with channels: #general, #daily, #builds, #bugs, #assets	One place for everything; pin key links in #general
Task board	Trello, GitHub Projects or Notion	Columns: Backlog · This week · Doing · Review · Done. Max 2 cards in Doing per person
Code and project	Git on GitHub or GitLab, with Git LFS for large binaries	Add the engine's .gitignore on day 1
Engine	Whatever the programmers are fastest in (Godot, Unity, Unreal, GameMaker, etc.)	Check the jam's rules on engines and platforms first
Art and audio	Shared drive folder for source files; only exported files go in the repo	Agree sizes, palette and naming before drawing anything
Builds	One shared build page (itch.io draft page works well)	Upload a build at every gate so anyone can play the latest

Avoid merge pain

- Work on short-lived branches and merge to main at least daily.
- Two people never edit the same scene or level file at once. Split work into separate scenes or prefabs and say in #daily which file you are in.
- main must always open and run. If you break it, fixing it is your first task.

Naming convention (agree on day 1): lowercase with underscores, type first, e.g. `spr_player_run.png`, `sfx_jump_01.wav`, `lvl_02_cave`.

Scope rules

Plan a game you could finish in 10 days; the other 11 go to bugs, polish, surprises and real life.

1. **Sort every feature into three buckets on day 2.** Must (the game is broken without it), Should (clearly better with it), Could (nice if time allows). Build all Musts before touching a Should.
2. **One core mechanic, done well.** A small game that feels good beats a large one that feels unfinished. Judges often play for only a few minutes.
3. **The first 60 seconds matter most.** Clear goal, obvious controls, something fun right away.
4. **New idea after day 7?** Write it in the Could column. It only gets built if all Musts and Shoulds are done.
5. **Cut early, cut calmly.** At each weekly review, if a gate is at risk, drop the lowest Should. Nobody's work being cut is personal.
6. **Feature freeze is real.** After day 16: bug fixes, tuning, sound, juice and text only. No new systems.
7. **Always have a submittable build.** From day 7 on, main should be something you could upload if the jam ended tonight.

Day 1 kickoff checklist

Run this as one 60–90 minute call right after the theme is announced.

- [ ] Read the jam rules together: engines, pre-made assets, AI use, platforms, team size, submission format and exact deadline time zone
- [ ] Everyone shares skills, what they want to learn, and weekly availability
- [ ] Agree roles and who is producer
- [ ] 20 minutes of solo brainstorming on the theme, then share and vote on the top 3 ideas
- [ ] Pick one idea; write a one-sentence pitch and the core loop (what the player does every 10 seconds)
- [ ] Write a one-page design doc: pitch, controls, win/lose, art style reference images, Must/Should/Could list
- [ ] Create Discord channels, task board, repo and shared drive; everyone clones and runs the empty project
- [ ] Agree daily check-in time and the overlap window
- [ ] Put the three gate dates in everyone's calendar

Submission checklist

Start on day 19 and finish on day 20; the jam site will be slow in the final hours.

- [ ] Final build exported for every target platform, and web build if allowed (browser games get played far more)
- [ ] Tested on a machine that is not the developer's, from a clean download
- [ ] Title screen, how-to-play or on-screen control hints, and a working restart
- [ ] Volume is sane, and there is a mute or volume option
- [ ] Game page: title, short pitch, 3–5 screenshots, a GIF, controls, credits for all three members
- [ ] Credits and licences for any third-party assets, fonts or music
- [ ] Submitted with all team members linked, then played once more from the jam page
- [ ] Post-jam: play and rate other entries (many jams reward this), then hold a 30-minute retro on what to keep and change